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From: john.watson <john.watson@pdq.net>
Sent: Tue, 23 Oct 2001 05:19:07 -0700 (PDT)
To: Watson, Kimberly <kimberly.watson@enron.com>
Subject: FWD: [ordinarylife] Summary of Oct. 21, 2001

FYI. ILY. SYWN? JTW.

>===== Original Message From ordinarylife-owner@yahoogroups.com =====
ORDINARY LIFE - Thoughts and Ideas to Help You Live a Happier Life

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Summary of October 21, 2001

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Dear Folks ?

This week's gathering focused on how, in light of our present circumstances, can we learn to practice a true present and enjoy the good that is all around us?

We must develop
Wisdom about the way life works,
Skill in making life work for us, and
Faith that will sustain us in all times.

The blackest, bleakest day in Christian history was essential for the brightest.

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Full text of the presentation

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Noticing and Enjoying Strawberries

In the e-mail preview of our time together today I told the following story. It is a very famous story from the Buddhist tradition:

The story is of a monk who was fleeing a tiger. He ran to the edge of a cliff and, being unable to stop himself, went over the edge. On the way down he caught the branch of a tree. He had been saved. He looked down and, way below on the ground, was another tiger. He must

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hang on with all his might. No way to go back up and certain death below. As he was hanging there, he glanced aside and saw a strawberry on a bush growing from the edge of the cliff beside him. He let go of the limb with one hand, picked the strawberry and savored it.

This story, of course, is a parable. It is told to illustrate the importance of developing the ability to enjoy a true present.

Our present circumstances are certainly chaotic are they not? How are we to develop the ability to enjoy the delicious strawberry that is just within reach? Indeed, how can we develop the ability even to notice that the strawberry is there? That's what our time together is going to be about today - developing the ability to notice and enjoy strawberries even when things fall apart.

Let me begin with some preliminary observations just to make sure we are all on the same page.

In the last fourteen years, I have given almost 700 different talks. That's a lot. Does anyone have that much to say?

The answer to that is, "No!" Twenty years or so ago, working with my teacher/mentor Carlyle Marney, I came up with something of a creed. I could put the entire Christian faith in less than fifty words. Here they are:

God is in our history with a searching love.
Jesus Christ is central.
The cross is unavoidable.
Church is a community of believers and there is no salvation by one's self. That is to say, faith is relational.
Discipline is required.
We can live an assured hope. That is to say, there is a saving possibility in every situation.

That, from a Christian perspective, is what we have to talk about. What changes is
our understanding of it,
our circumstances and
us.

One of the things that has changed, of course, is that on 9/11 we began to be forced to notice what is going on around us. Mostly, however, we have seen just tigers chasing us and a huge abyss below us with more tigers. You don't hear much talk about delicious

strawberries. Indeed, we are frantically looking for the branch to hold on to. I hope that you get at least that much here.

I was working out at my athletic club on Wednesday and was struggling away reading about Methodist Polity while doing the stair-master. On a recumbent bike in front of me was a man - I admire him for his spunk; 82 and still working out daily - who was pontificating about how to deal with our nation's current crisis. He went on and on about how "the only way to fight terrorism is with terrorism."

Like you, I have seen the newspapers, magazines and listened to the programs on radio and television. I found it funny as all get-out that on one of the television news magazine programs this past week they were talking about how we were becoming a nation of terrorized people. Hello! They are the ones who are stirring up the fear. "What should you have in your survival kit? Stay tuned for the news that follows." Give me a break.

Yet the fact is that our government officials are saying more terrorist attacks are likely to take place in this country. How do we live with that?

I do not want to ignore or deny the tigers chasing us or the abyss. I do want what my teaching is about to help us notice and enjoy the strawberries.

This circumstance that we find ourselves in can be the perfect teaching moment for us.

We don't like this because we have come in our culture to value comfort so much. But the feelings of loss and fear that we have experienced since 9/11 can show us, with terrifying clarity, exactly what our spiritual work needs to be.

Not only has an emphasis on comfort seduced us away from reality but also so has the need for each of us to appear to the other that we've got it all together.

Let me be very clear: spiritual practice isn't about being good; it is about waking up.

One day Gabriel was walking about in the heavenly realm. He came upon God and it was apparent that God was very depressed. Gabriel said to God, "What's the matter?" God said, pointing to the earth, "Look at what a mess they have made of everything. Nothing is going like I had

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hoped it would. I'm going to destroy the lot of them."

"But you can't do that," Gabriel said.

"And why not? I'm God, the Almighty. I can do whatever I wish."

"Because," said Gabriel, "you promised."

"I did?"

"Yes. At the time of the great flood."

"Well, then, I'm going to get rid of most of them. Send someone to go over all the earth and find the truly righteous. Give to each of the righteous a small brass plaque so that when I send the angel of death to destroy, the angel of death will be able to distinguish the righteous from those who are not."

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